



stretches from southeastern France through Italy, Switzerland, Liechtenstein, Austria, and into Slovenia. The Alps can be divided into four main climatic regions, although virtually every valley has a slightly different

climate. Until recently, the mountains were considerable barriers to travel, so people in these areas developed in separate clusters resulting in different traditions, languages, and dialects.



HEADING FOR THE HILLS

During the winter, the cows must be kept away from the snowy slopes and eat hay in the valley. In the middle of June, they are herded back up the mountains. A whole day is dedicated to the task. People armed with sticks keep the cows moving if they get distracted by the juicy grass.

Most Swiss are Christian, with the numbers divided almost equally between Catholics and Protestants.



MAKING HAY

June and July are a particularly busy time for Alpine farmers. While their cows are enjoying the grass high above the treeline, the farmers gather the grass growing on the lower slopes to make hay. It is heaped into nets and hauled away to be stored in haylofts. This hay will provide the cattle with food during the long winter to come.

